

PHALANX AND CAVALRY

THE BATTLE OF ISSUS

The Macedonian army of Alexander the Great achieved remarkable conquests in the 4th century BCE, invading and destroying the mighty Persian Empire. Alexander's defeat of the Persians at Issus in 333BCE exemplified the Macedonian use of infantry phalanxes flanked by heavy cavalry.

As Alexander advanced along the eastern Mediterranean coast, the Persian ruler Darius III led an army through Syria to intercept him, reaching the sea behind Alexander's line of march. The Macedonians turned back and confronted Darius at Issus on a plain between the sea and the foothills of the Amanus Mountains. Alexander's army was outnumbered – possibly 40,000 men to the Persians' 100,000 – but the restricted battlefield made it difficult for Darius to use his larger force to outflank the Macedonian line.

The Persians took up a position behind a river, fortifying its banks with wooden palisades. On the other side of the river, Alexander arranged his forces in a traditional fashion. His elite Companion cavalry took up position on the right, by the foothills, and the subsidiary Thessalian cavalry on the left, beside the sea. In the centre were the infantry – most of them organized into tightknit phalanxes armed with long, two-handed sarissa pikes. The Macedonian phalanxes were usually 16 ranks deep, but at Issus the ranks were thinned to eight to spread the troops more widely. The Macedonians also deployed more flexible hypaspists – elite infantry equipped with shorter spears, swords, and pikes – and swarms of light skirmishing troops armed with bows, javelins, and slings.

Darius opened the battle, sending soldiers to infiltrate through the hills, but the Macedonian skirmishers countered this outflanking manoeuvre, halting the Persians with arrows and stones. The main body of heavily armoured Persian cavalry, supported by slingers running alongside the

horses, charged along the beach on the Macedonian left, but was contained and then repulsed by the Thessalian horsemen. In the centre, Alexander ordered his infantry to advance against the Persian line, where Greek mercenary hoplites employed by Darius were drawn up in phalanxes with their traditional bronze armour, shields, and spears. As the Macedonian foot soldiers began to ford the river and scale the palisades on the far side, their own phalanxes lost formation, opening gaps in the ranks of pikes into which the enemy could penetrate.

TACTICAL PROWESS

The struggle in the centre, however, was not Alexander's main tactical gambit – he intended to triumph through a cavalry charge on the right. With Alexander himself at their head, the Companion cavalry rode forward. The horsemen wore bronze cuirasses and helmets, but did not carry shields. Each was armed with a lance and a sword, mostly the curvaceous *kopis*. Having neither saddle nor stirrups, the men gripped their mounts firmly with their knees as they smashed into a mix of Persian light infantry, archers, and cavalry. The point of attack was well chosen, and the Persian left wing collapsed in the face of the onslaught. Already engaged with the Macedonian infantry to their front, Darius's Greek mercenaries were now exposed to cavalry attack from the flank and rear. Darius himself, on a command chariot behind his army, was also under threat. The Persian emperor fled the field, leaving his soldiers to be massacred or to scatter in search of safety.

